

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · EPISODE 2

Ancient Egypt

Ancient Egypt History for Sleep

A Calm Night on the Nile

✦ ✦ ✦

A BEDTIME COMPANION

Two maps, a timeline from the first kings to the Rosetta Stone, the people and places you'll meet in the episode, and a short list of trusted books and museums, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

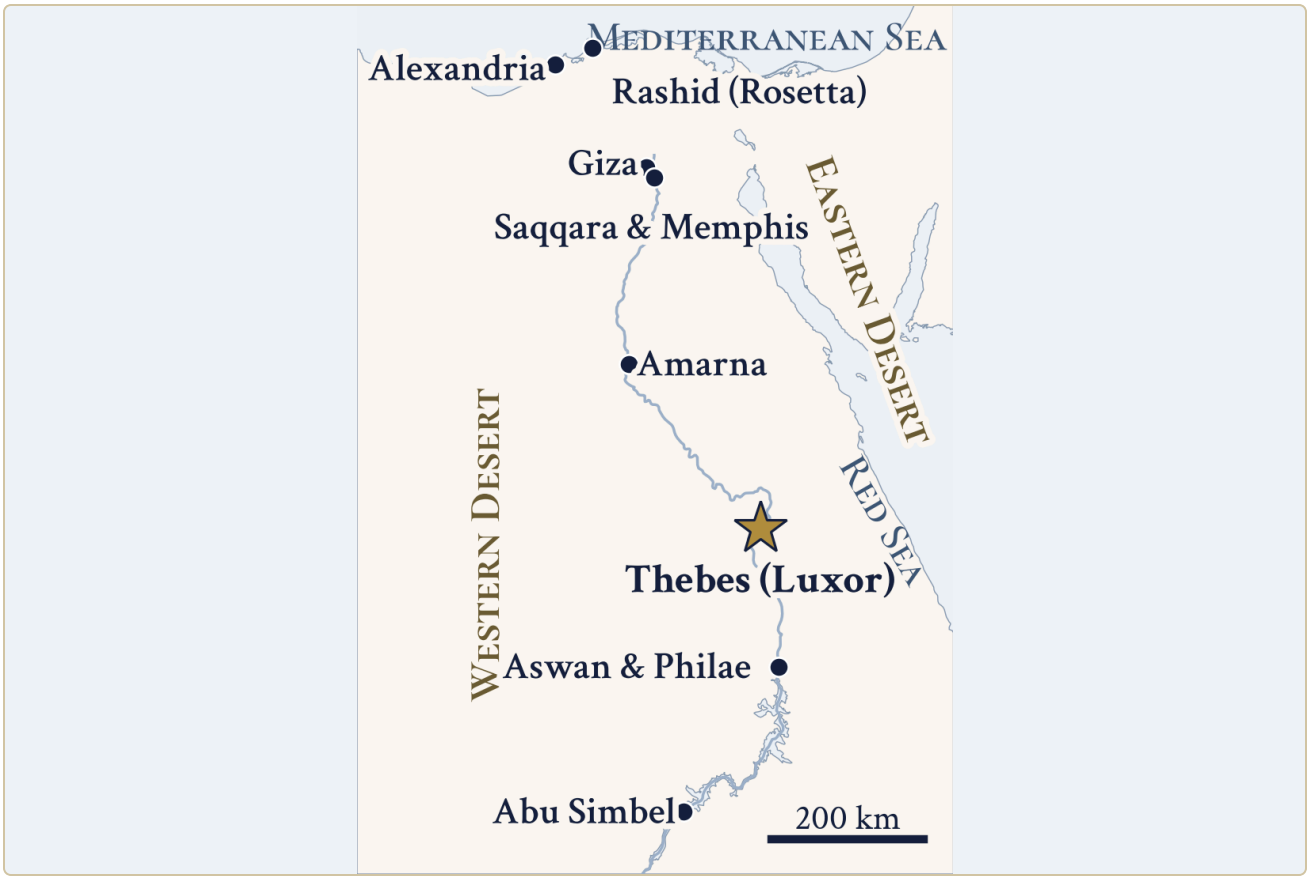
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A green ribbon through the desert

Let's begin by following the Nile through the desert.



Sites plotted at their real locations on a modern base map (Natural Earth). The Nile's course and the coast are modern; Lake Nasser was created by the Aswan High Dam in the 1960s.

AT A GLANCE

- Egyptians called the dark, flood-fed soil of the valley the Black Land
- The deserts on either side were the Red Land
- The river runs north
- So Upper Egypt lies in the south, and Lower Egypt in the Delta

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Places you'll visit in the episode

Ten places from the episode, from Giza to Abu Simbel.

Giza · The pyramids of Khufu, Khafre and Menkaure, and the Great Sphinx.

Saqqara · Djoser's Step Pyramid, designed by tradition by Imhotep, in the Third Dynasty.

Dahshur · The Bent and Red Pyramids, experiments on the way to the true pyramid.

Memphis · The early capital, near the meeting of the valley and the Delta.

Amarna · Akhenaten's new city for the Aten, abandoned after his death.

Thebes · The southern capital, with Karnak, Luxor Temple and the Valley of the Kings.

Deir el-Bahri · Hatshepsut's terraced temple, with reliefs of the voyage to Punt.

Deir el-Medina · The village of the royal tomb builders, rich in letters and records.

Abu Simbel · Ramesses II's rock temples, moved to higher ground in the 1960s.

Alexandria · Alexander's city of 332 BCE, home of the Library and the Pharos.

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THREE THOUSAND YEARS, SLOWLY

A timeline of the Nile kingdoms

Three thousand years along the Nile, one quiet step at a time.

AT A GLANCE

c. 3100 BCE
Egypt is unified

Mid-26th c. BCE
The Great Pyramid

1279–1213 BCE
Ramesses II

31–30 BCE
A Roman province

1922
Tutankhamun's tomb

Dates follow The Oxford History of Ancient Egypt; the earliest are approximate.

Before c. 3100 BCE	Naqada culture farmers and towns grow along the Nile in Upper Egypt.
c. 3100 BCE	Egypt is unified; the Narmer Palette shows a king wearing both crowns.
c. 2686–2125 BCE	The Old Kingdom.
Third Dynasty	Djoser's Step Pyramid rises at Saqqara.
Mid-26th c. BCE	The Great Pyramid of Khufu is built at Giza.
c. 2160–2055 BCE	First Intermediate Period: low floods and local rulers.
c. 2055 BCE	Egypt is reunited from Thebes: the Middle Kingdom begins.
c. 1650–1550 BCE	The Hyksos rule the north from Avaris.
c. 1550–1069 BCE	The New Kingdom, with royal tombs in the Valley of the Kings.

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THREE THOUSAND YEARS, SLOWLY

A timeline of the Nile kingdoms

The story goes on from here, slowly.



c. 1473–1458 BCE	Hatshepsut rules as pharaoh.
c. 1352–1336 BCE	Akhenaten worships the Aten and builds Amarna.
c. 1336–1327 BCE	The short reign of Tutankhamun.
1279–1213 BCE	The long reign of Ramesses II; Kadesh, and later a treaty with the Hittites.
c. 1157 BCE	Tomb builders of Deir el-Medina strike over late rations, under Ramesses III.
332 BCE	Alexander the Great arrives; Alexandria is founded.
31–30 BCE	Actium, and the death of Cleopatra VII; Egypt becomes a Roman province.

THREE THOUSAND YEARS, SLOWLY

A timeline of the Nile kingdoms

394 CE	The last known hieroglyphic inscription is carved at Philae.
1799	The Rosetta Stone is found at Rashid.
1822	Champollion announces his decipherment of hieroglyphs.
1922	Howard Carter finds the tomb of Tutankhamun.
1964–1968	Abu Simbel is moved above the rising waters of Lake Nasser.

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An empire beyond the river

Now let's step back and look at Egypt's neighbours.



Approximate extent of Egypt and its neighbours around 1500 BCE, at the start of the New Kingdom, simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset; borders are approximate. In the following centuries Egyptian armies campaigned north to Megiddo and Kadesh and far south into Nubia.

People you'll meet

The kings, queens and scholars you'll meet along the way.

Narmer · The king of the Narmer Palette, often linked with the unification of Egypt.

Imhotep · By tradition the designer of Djoser's Step Pyramid, later honoured as a sage.

Khufu · Builder of the Great Pyramid of Giza, in the Fourth Dynasty.

Sinuhe · Hero of a famous Middle Kingdom story of exile and homecoming.

Hatshepsut · A woman who ruled as pharaoh; builder of the temple at Deir el-Bahri.

Thutmose III · Warrior king whose army marched through a narrow pass to Megiddo.

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People you'll meet

Akhenaten & Nefertiti · The royal couple of the Aten and the city of Amarna.

Tutankhamun · A young king whose nearly intact tomb was found in 1922.

Ramesses II · Reigned some 66 years; builder of Abu Simbel and the Ramesseum.

Cleopatra VII · Last ruler of the Ptolemaic dynasty; died in 30 BCE.

Champollion · French scholar who cracked hieroglyphs in 1822, building on Thomas Young.

Howard Carter · Archaeologist who, with Lord Carnarvon, saw "wonderful things".

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WHILE YOU LISTEN

Things to spot, legend and history

A few things to listen for, and a note on legend and history.

THINGS TO SPOT IN THE EPISODE

- The Narmer Palette, with a king wearing both crowns
- Djoser's Step Pyramid at Saqqara
- Hatshepsut's reliefs of the voyage to Punt
- The tomb builders of Deir el-Medina striking over late rations
- The Rosetta Stone, found at Rashid in 1799

LEGEND OR HISTORY?

Some popular ideas about Egypt are not supported by the evidence. The pyramids were built by organised, rotating crews who were housed and fed at Giza, not by armies of chained slaves. And the many stories about Cleopatra come mostly from later Roman writers. The episode keeps these apart from what the sources and the monuments show.





Artistic impressions of the hypostyle hall at Karnak and of Abu Simbel at sunrise, made for the episode. They are not historical records.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Books to read

If you'd like to wander a little further, here are some trusted places to start.

The Rise and Fall of Ancient Egypt ↗, Toby Wilkinson (Random House, 2013).

The Oxford History of Ancient Egypt ↗, ed. Ian Shaw (Oxford University Press, 2003).

Red Land, Black Land: Daily Life in Ancient Egypt ↗, Barbara Mertz (Harper, 2009).

Temples, Tombs, and Hieroglyphs ↗, Barbara Mertz (Harper, 2009).

The Woman Who Would Be King: Hatshepsut's Rise to Power ↗, Kara Cooney (Broadway, 2015).

The Complete Gods and Goddesses of Ancient Egypt ↗, Richard H. Wilkinson (Thames & Hudson).

📚 FIND THESE BOOKS — TAP HERE →

Full reading list ↗

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Museums, places and one last thought

Museums & places

British Museum, London: the Rosetta Stone and the Papyrus of Ani.

Royal Ontario Museum, Toronto: galleries of ancient Egypt.

Museum of Fine Arts, Boston: the great Giza collection.

Rosicrucian Egyptian Museum, San Jose.

A BEDTIME QUESTION

If you could spend one evening by the Nile, would you choose Giza, Thebes or Abu Simbel?

"Let the river slow now in your mind. Let the temples grow dim and kind. You have nowhere to be, and nothing left to carry."

LISTEN TO THE FULL EPISODE ON YOUTUBE OR YOUTUBE MUSIC

Watch the episode: youtube.com/watch?v=XgBRHvoxtyo

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